

Other Types of Clutter & Decluttering Exercise Transcript

Next form of clutter that we will be looking at is alignment. Alignment of text in the graphic is very important to convey the right meaning. We as humans are preferring to read the text from top to bottom, from left to right.

A centred text does not carry the attention same as the text that is aligned towards the left. If you can see the difference between these two graphics though the text content is similar is just the alignment. In the first graphic the text is aligned in the centre is more taxing to read as compared to the text that is on the right side which is aligned left side.

So while presenting a visual if you have text element to be incorporated ensure it is aligned so that it gives the maximum impact. Another issue is the use of diagonal elements. For example in the visual the diagram uses two diagonal lines connecting to two bars to the narration of the text.

This is cognitively very displeasing and you can use the white space and dominate the graphic close to the text and get the same meaning and the eye is able to make the connections. We will now talk a very important aspect of clutter called white spaces. White spaces can be strategically used in a visual to bring impact and depth to the content that we are presenting.

For example the graphic on the right has lot of text which is placed all over the body of the graphic. This is neither giving the impact but instead it is causing the clutter. As opposed to this look at the graphic on the right side where the text is condensed and highlighted at right places bringing in the necessary impact and leaving the white space to build the contrast naturally into the graphic creating an effect and causing the people to have more attention on to the graphic.

You can also look at the use of white space at the axis labels where in the first case they are little larger in font closely placed not giving impact but in the later case they are spaced just equally and are giving a clear white space around the label giving the impact that they are distinct categories and easily perceptible to human eye. Likewise the white space is brought in between the text narration and the title to create the impact separate impact for the text narration and the diagonal lines are also loosed so that it can be clearly connected to the data point. Similarly the feedback the title of the similarly the title of the chart is also highlighted with white space around to bring in the impact.

White spaces can be used strategically to improve the effect of your visualisation. We will now look at non-strategic use of contrast. Clutter can be removed by use of contrast.

For example the graphic on the left side compares the weighted performance index of different types of we will now compare another class of clutter called non-strategic use

of contrast. Contrast like white spaces is a strategic element. You can use contrast in your visuals to build intensity.

For example look at the graphic on the left side it compares the performance of a company vis-a-vis competitors along five dimensions. Though the graphic is trying to convey some information it is not able to present a consistent story nor one is able to draw any lessons from it directly without any assistance. Somebody has to provide context to you to understand this particular graphic.

As opposed to this modifying this graphic as a horizontal bar and using the blue line to represent one own business and competition using dark grey or light grey is able one is able to directly see the comparison of the business performance vis-a-vis its competitors without much help. The second graph is cognitively very easy and easy to perceive and therefore conveying the meaning more effectively than the first graph. If you compare the difference between the two graphs is very simple.

You have changed the chart type qualitatively there is not much of a difference because you are just using the numerical values on the both the graphs. However the distinction element is the contrast. You have used the contrasting colours of blue and light grey to represent your own business and competitors and the five dimensions are presented distinctly immediately grabbing the attention of the people whoever looking at the graph to understand how the business is performing vis-a-vis its competitors.

We will now look at decluttering. Decluttering is an exercise where you try to remove the clutter in the visual or try to improve the effectiveness of visual by adding or removing certain elements and making it more effective. Take a look at the graph.

We will now do the decluttering exercise with the help of an example. The task here is there was a company in which a team is tasked with receiving internal customer complaints and resolving them. Their productivity is measured by the number of tickets received and number of tickets processed over the months.

There is no delay if you see between the number of tickets received and number of tickets processed up until May and after May there is slight dip in the performance of the team during which period during May June certain team members have exited and they have not been replaced. Now the question is how to convince the top management that there is a need for additional hires or even to answer the question is there a need for having additional hires. This graphic is trying to address this particular question and how you can see that it is clearly showing an impact on the productivity of the team and therefore it is required for taking additional hires depending on the situation.

However our objective is not with the action but with the visual. Now we will look how better this visual can be designed and what are the steps involved in it. First of all look at the visual what are the elements that are present in the visual.

You have the graph which is a simple line chart because it is showing a trend over a period in time number of complaints received and number of complaints resolved and these are lines with markers there are grid lines there is label and there are 300 tickets 250 tickets these are the number of tickets received and resolved and then you have months then you have legend indicating the tickets received and the tickets processed and the border for the graph. Ask the question who is our audience before we do any decluttering exercise we need to ask the question who is our audience and what is the purpose of the visual to them. In this visual we have explained the question is to address the in this visual we have said the question is to help the management make a decision to hire additional people to improve the productivity.

The following productivity is already established the question is how to address this. So there is no need for having a border the border is not adding any value we will start with removing the border. Borders are not needed because the white space provides the better contrast.

At some points borders might be needed to distinguish the text from the graphic but in most cases it is better not to have the border. The next thing we do is to remove the grid lines. Grid lines are not needed in this case because you can clearly see the numbers and you can make a comparison.

There is no need for grid lines and that can also be removed therefore the graphic becomes even more clearer. We can remove the data markers also because they are not adding any value or conveying any additional meaning. Data markers make sense only if you use them to distinguish categories when there are multiple series.

In this case there are only two series and there is no need for having data markers. Removing them will give a pleasing appeal to the lines as opposed to the data markers which break cognition in the continuity paradigm. So go back to the Gestalt principles if something is continuous our mind perceives them to follow a trend.

The markers though are in the same colour are blocking cognition. You can remove them and create smooth lines which are even more easier on the eyes. Next look at the axis labels.

Tickets do not come in fractional numbers therefore there is no point in keeping double digits or two spaces after decimal. You can truncate them and make it simple numerical values like 100 300. This would give the labels even more good appeal and save the space and make them easy to read.

Likewise on the x-axis there is no need to represent the months in full name in horizontal text. One more line of caution or suggestion whenever possible there is no need to present text in any other angular form. It is better to present text in horizontal way where we are used to read.

One more word of caution it is always advised not to present text in an angular format.

It is best to present them in horizontal format in which we are accustomed to read. Vertical text and horizontal text take more cognitive ability and therefore load on the graphic therefore make it difficult to read.

So wherever possible try to remove the angular text and replace it with horizontal text. In this case we have also removed the horizontal name month names with shorter month names which are easily understood. If these are something common there is no need to give the full form we can use the abbreviations and make it simpler and therefore having less cognitive load on the audience.

There you can now see we have removed many things like the border we have removed. We have removed the decimals from the label shortened the labels on x-axis and removed the grid lines. The graphic is much more pleasing now but still can be made better and in fact there is lot of redundant information that can be removed and can be better portrayed.

We can remove the legend box directly and use the labels to beside the graph to convey the meaning. We have only two categories and using the text box to write received tickets and processed tickets gives much more sharper meaning than requiring the person to go back to the legend and relate the series. Now in the first graph we have to see the legend and connect back to the graph.

So there is some amount of extra effort required to look at the legend and look back at the graph. We can solve that problem by directly moving the labels right next to the series. Of course there is a limitation here you can do this only if there are limited series and there is some amount of spacing between them so that the texts can be placed without cluttering the diagram.

Otherwise you would be introducing clutter into the diagram in that case it might be advisable to use the legend but in this particular case because there are only two categories you can as well label them right next to it and get away with the legend diagram bringing more clarity to the visual. This does not end here you can further improvise the graphics by doing this. You can consistently colour the legend consistently colour the labels you can improvise the graphic further by consistent colours.

You can colour the labels in line with the series so that it is naturally appealing to the audience that blue represents the received tickets red represents to the process tickets and there is a divergence in the productivity after the month of July. This is how you can improve the graphic further and finally this is how it looks. Look at the graph that we started with and then look at the graph that we have now processed.

The later graph is very clear effective and directly gives the message and effectively uses the colour and contrast principles and brings out the communication that we want to give to the management very clearly and with very less cognitive load. This is an



example of decluttering exercise that you can do to improve your visuals. Again a word of caution not all steps might be relevant to the particular case in hand but always ask whether an additional element is adding any value if not or if it is adding a marginal value is better to remove the element and keep the graphics simple clean and clear.

Thank you

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